Indian core competence in rocketry has been firmly established again, beyond any doubt. The robust civilian space industry and viable missilebased defences has brought India into the select club of nations that cal themselves superpowers. Always encouraged to fol ow Buddha's or Gandhi's teachings, how and why did India become a missile power is a question that needs to be answered for future generations.

Two centuries of subjugation, oppression and denial have failed to kil the creativity and capability of the Indian people. Within just a decade of gaining independence and achieving sovereignty, Indian Space and Atomic Energy Programmes were launched with a perfect orientation towards peaceful applications. There were neither funds for investing in missile development nor any established requirement from the Armed Forces. The bitter experiences of 1962 forced us to take the basic first steps towards missile development.

Would a Prithvi suffice? Would the indigenous development of four or five missile systems make us sufficiently strong? Or would having nuclear weapons make us stronger? Missiles and atomic weapons are merely